

The Den of the Square Lion

What is Varaz up to? He is putting a cushion on one side of the room, but he already has one, at the other side? She looks at Abrangih, who just shrugs her shoulders.

—“You think someone else is coming?”

—“Like aunt Peristerá? Remember, she once told us some funny stories.”

Siavash, sitting right behind her, must have heard, for he replied.

—“Mommy is in Ray, with grandma number one.”

That solved that. Not aunt Peristerá. But Siavash’s numbering of his grandmama’s made no sense. Should mother Gordiyag not be number one? But her thoughts got interrupted by Varaz.

—“Okay, children. As you can see, today we will have two storytellers.”

—“Why?”

—“For there will be two stories! Until they become one!”

—“Huh?”

—“Varaz, who’s going to be the second storyteller?”

—“Mᵉ!”

—“Huh? But you said...”

—“The other me!”

—“Who? What?”

—“Don’t you see him?”

They all look around. Of course, nobody else is there.

—“You’re pulling our leg, Varaz. There is no one else here.”

—“But I always see him.”

—“Where?”

—“In the water of the pond. And when I wave, he waves back. And when I wink with my right eye, he winks back with his left one. But when I say *drōd* [hello], he opens his mouth, but no sounds comes out of it.”

Oh! She figured it out! He is talking about his reflection in the water.

—“It’s your reflection, Varaz.”

—“My mirror twin. As handsome as the original, ha, ha.”

—“But as you said, Varaz, your mirror image cannot speak. How is he going to tell the second tale.”

Her brother brings up a good point.

—“Very well observed, Shirowe. I guess, I will have to speak in his stead. Don’t worry, children, you won’t notice the difference—after all we look

identical—well, as long as I don't wink, ha, ha. But the tale will be as riveting as always, well, twice as much, in fact."

He likes to experiment with new story telling techniques, and this one will require a lot of him moving around. It'll be a good exercise. But it also requires perfect timing. That's the real challenge. So, better get started. He goes to the left corner and sits down on the cushion he has put there.

THE sun is setting on the Holy City, and in the twilight, he can barely keep up with the high priest. ♣

—"Who is he, Varaz?"

ONLY by listening careful to their conversation, we might be able to figure it out.

~"Your Eminence, why the rush?"

~"I want to get there before my Mistress is out."

~"Why? She did not approve of this trip?"

~"That's not it. But when she comes out, I'll have to worship Her. And we don't really have time for that now!" Children, where are these two going? What are they up to? ♣

He quickly gets up and moves to the other side of the room.

THE sun is setting on the Land of Frankincense and Spices, and in the twilight, they can barely see the big elephant.

~"Look, on top of that elephant. It's the Lion Queen of Sheba! And she is wearing her big red ruby."

~"Is that not where all her magic comes from?"

~"It is. And there, that's King Darius the Mede. Look, he pulls his bow and ..." They can see the Queen of Sheba tumble from her elephant.

~"He got her! Yay! The Queen is no more!"

~"Well, I wouldn't celebrate too quickly. We, royals of the female persuasion, we are made of sterner stuff." She is right. The Queen gets back up. But without her ruby, she lost all her power. And so, she has no choice but to run while King Darius the Mede enters triumphantly her palace. The Land of Frankincense and Spices has been freed from the Queen's evil rule! Time for some celebration. ♣

It's a little confusing. Who is who in this story. Well, two stories?

—"Varaz, you still haven't told us who they are!"

He moves back to the first cushion.

WELL, let's find out, shall we.

~“I think you'll have to stop, Your Eminence,” he points upward, “She has come out.” The high priest looks up and it's true. The moon has come out.

~“O Grand Mistress of the Night, Great is Thy beauty that ariseth from Thy shining light.¹” The high priest continues his prayer, while his guide decides to find out where the palace of the King of the Jews is from two young men passing by. They wave at him.

~“Hello, visitors from abroad. Welcome to the City. I am Emmaus and this is my friend Cleopas.”

~“May I ask, dear citizens of the Holy City, where does your king live?”

~“King?”

~“Yes, the King of the Jews.”

~“Oh, Him! We crucified Him long time ago—his cross is laying somewhere on that hill,” he shrugs his shoulders, “But now the Patriarch is in charge. I am curious, are you the only strangers in Jerusalem who do not know the things that have taken place here?²”

~“Uhm, no, I was not aware. I have been busy sailing the seven seas.”

~“Well, it's on land that things happen, dear Captain.”

~“So it seems.” See, children, it's the Captain who has brought the high priest of the Moon goddess to Jerusalem. ♣

—“Why?”

He gets up and walks to the other cushion.

WE will soon enough find out. But there is another mission that needs to be briefed.

~“Your Majesty, we certainly can carry out that task for you. Not a problem!”

~“That would be like so nice, Princess, as I am all tied up here. Governing business and all the like,” King Darius the

¹Homeric Hymn 32.

²Luke, 24.18.

Mede glances at her companion, "But if I may ask, before you leave, dear Princess, this fellow here, is he like your...? *Alā*, I just ask, because, you know, I have like this handsome son. Kurosh [Cyrus] the Persian is his name. He is going to do like great stuff. And to have a lovely princess like yourself beside him. And he would be all like: daddy, I like her. Can she not be like my queen?" Does the Knight notice a little hesitation in the Princess's reply! But no, it was just a *shnoshag*—he imitates her sneezing—atchoo! She firmly rebukes the offer.

~"Your Majesty, this here is my valiant Knight and together we fight for Justice and All that is Right. Together, we will, as you asked, take the flying carpet that the evil queen of Sheba had stolen from King Solomon of the Jews, back to its rightful owner! We promise," she bows before King Darius the Mede, "Please send you son our regards. I am sure he is going to find a fair maiden to become his dearly loved wife." See, children, with a little patience we can find out the who and the what! 🍀

Wow. A story of the Captain and another of the Princess and her Knight, all in one. Can it get any better!

—"Yay!"

Time to swap cushions.

WHEN the high priest has finished worshipping his deity, the Captain explains that there is a change of plan. No longer to a king but to a patriarch will they have to make their case.

~"Do you think the Patriarch will help us fight the evil Lion Queen of Sheba?"

~"Well, let's find out." As they are about to start their walk to the episcopal palace, the high priest starts to shiver.

~"At night, it gets pretty cold here."

~"Yeah, you might wanna put on a cape."

~"*Pargast*! I forgot to bring one," the high priest turns around, "Captain, could you be a dear and go fetch my cape? I left it in the closet in my chamber."

~"You want me to go all the way back to the Land of Frank-

incense and Spices?" See, that's where the high priest came from.

~"It's my lucky charm cape? I am sure that with it, we can convince the Patriarch to help us. Besides, my Mistress is peeping through the clouds, and she needs some more attention." The Captain sighs. This long voyage just to fetch a cape! Luckily, in stories, time doesn't matter, and so, at the benevolence of the storyteller, he'd better be back before breakfast. ♪

—"But Varaz, King Darius defeated already the evil Queen. Why are they going to ask for help?"

—"But they don't know that yet. Hopefully, someone will tell the Captain," another switch, "meanwhile..."

JUST as the Captain leaves to the Land of Frankincense and Spices to fetch the moon priest's cape, who comes flying in the sky from that very same land? ♪

—"The Princess and her Knight!"

Indeed. So, now they have to find King Solomon the Jew to return his carpet. ♪

—"But, Varaz, the King of the Jews is dead," he looks at Āzar with a what-did-I-just-tell-you face, "...oh, right, they don't know that yet, hee, hee."

THE Princess spots two youngsters walking on the road.
~"Drōd [Hello]."

~"Hello, visitors from abroad. Welcome to the City. I am Emmaus and this is my friend Cleopas."

~"Handsome lads, where can we find the palace of the King of the Jews?" Emmaus looks at his friends and throws his hands in the air.

~"Someone should write all this down, in some acts or so, so that it would be witnessed in all of Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth.³ And hopefully, then foreigners won't keep bothering us with these stupid questions!" The Knight looks a little offended, so, Cleopas quickly adds.

~"Pardon my friend, but apparently strangers don't not know the things that have taken place in our beloved city. There is

³Acts, 1.8.

no King of the Jews anymore! Go talk to the Patriarch. Perhaps you can accompany those other two ignoramuses."

~"Other two?" He points to the high priest a little further down the road, who is making his invocations to his Moon Mistress. They politely wait until he is finished. The man, however, seems in quite some distress, so the Princess gently asks.

~"Dear Sire, pardon our interruption. But we heard you too sought an audience with the Kings of the Jews, only to find out that he has been replaced by the Patriarch. We too were seeking the King's audience. May I ask, what was the purpose of your visit?"

~"To help for his assistance in defeating an evil queen who rules my land. And what was yours?"

~"To return a treasure stolen by another evil queen."

~"The world has gone to smithereens! Two evil queens! And probably many more to come! And that is not the worst of it!" The Knight is curious what could be worse, but the Princess all of a sudden has a hunch.

~"What land is it that your evil queen is devastating?"

~"A marvelous land, where the air smells like frankincense and the water is full of spices."

~"The Land of Frankincense and Spices?"

~"Yeah, that one."

~"And the evil queen, is that the Lion Queen of Sheba?"

~"The very monster who wants to turn my country into a wasteland for her lions." The Princess and the Knight start laughing. Children, they can't stop laughing. And all the while, the high priest is getting angrier and angrier. The Princess notices it and so, she quickly reassures him.

~"Dear Sire, do not agonize any further. We also came from that land and we witnessed how King Darius the Mede defeated the evil Queen. Your country is safe." The holy man falls on his knees from joy and lifts his arms up in praise.

~"O Hiding One, we laud Thee Who reifies our nocturnal petitions by matins' dawn! Hallelujah!"

~"Hiding One?"

~"Well, yeah, don't you see the clouds?" The Knight is com-

pletely mystified by the priest's reply, but the Princess has figured it out.

~"Praised be the great Moon Goddess for delivering us from this evil: the Queen of Sheba is no longer queen of Sheba," see children, Sheba is the old name for the Land of Frankincense and Spices, "And now, we came here to return the carpet she had stolen from King Solomon."

~"Who no longer is alive, apparently. But the good news is that at least I don't need him anymore. And as to your carpet, I guess, the Patriarch could use one too."

~"Well, it's actually a flying one. Look, it's hovering right there."

~"Oh, what an auspicious occurrence! Now that my land is secure, I have an even more hallowed task to perform. And that carpet, it could really help me. For a great misfortune has befallen my Mistress, Serene Selene."

~"Oh, dear. What happened?" The high priest shakes his head and sits down. The gravity of it all! But meanwhile... 🐼

Like dangling them from a cliff, he jumps up and sits on the other cushion, while all their little heads are following him with open mouths.

—"What, Varaz?"

Here it is, the Temple of the Moon Goddess in the Land of Frankincense and Spices! The Captain quickly finds one of the acolytes and asks him to show his master's room. ~"Here, Captain Sailing-Seven-Seas-Searching..." As he is in a rush, he doesn't want to wait for the acolyte to say his full name.

~"Thanks, good man. Aha, here's the cape. Now you master can get an audience with the Patriarch of Jerusalem, to help him in his quest to kick the Queen of Sheba."

~"What purpose would that serve?"

~"To free you country!"

~"Free? From the Medes—or from The Parthians or the Persians—they all look the same to me. Anyway, why would we want that?"

~"What are you babbling about. What Medes?"

~"Darius the King of the Medes," the acolyte looks at him

with a surprised face, "Wait. You don't know?"

~"While I know what I don't know, I probably don't know anymore what I know, so you tell me."

~"King Darius the Mede came with a great multitude of ships—well, actually, it were only eight—wait, no six—two of them sunk—but anyway, with his brave men he marched to the Lion Queen's capital and defeated her. And so, she ran away crying into the woods. No need to kick her further. She lost her red ruby and now she's powerless."

~"Oh, wow! That's great news! Your master will be so pleased. Quick, hand me his cape, so that I can go back to tell him—hopefully by breakfast—about the good fortune your land has befallen." But when the Captain is about to return to his ship with the high priest's cape, a boy comes running towards them.

~"Run! A great calamity is going to befall us. O woe. Run!! Run!!!"

~"Boy, calm down. What do you mean?"

~"It's the rats! The Queen's rats!!" Children, did she turn from Lion Queen into Rat Queen? 🐀

—"Did she, Varaz?"

—"Let's find out what grave matters are transpiring."

Varaz has switched cushions again, but it still takes her a little to get that what follows is happening back in Jerusalem, with the Princess and her Knight.

THE high priest exclaims

~"Āy wāy! A piece fell off! A piece of my Mistress!"

~"What do you mean? From the Moon?" The Knight vaguely remembers some story.

~"Is it the semen of the Bull?"

~"What? Semen? What a lewd comment to make! Her spouse is the Sun and.... No, a stone has broken off from her Highness and it has fallen onto earth."

~"Where?"

~"We have to find out!"

~"Why?" The Knight should not perhaps have asked that, for the high priest looks very angrily at him.

~“Don’t you know that even a little grain of moon dust makes you fall a sleep.”

~“Moon dust?” ❧

—“Children, I have to ask you something. When you wake up in the morning. What is that in the corner of your eyes?”

Āzar looks at him with her big eyes—her mommy’s eyes.

—“That is moon dust, Varaz?”

—“And you have to rub it out, to wake up, right?”

SO, the high priest now exclaims

~“Imagine what a whole stone would do! We have to find it before a poor sod is morphed by moon dust, to no longer endure the power of sleep, as drowsiness will steal upon his frame.⁴” And so, the three climb on the carpet and start looking for a moon stone. Oh, there, children, do you see that too? ❧

He pretends to stand up and look.

—“What, Varaz?”

Giving him just enough time to plunge onto the other cushion.

Rats are gnawing on the big dam of the Moon Valley! That evil queen has sent them to eat away at its foundation. And if that dam breaks, *āy wāy*, a devastating flood will replace the beautiful orchards with others, only producing bitter fruit, fruitless bushes, and thorny trees.⁵

~“Captain,” the acolyte yells, “we have to do something!”

~“Rats? Let’s see. Fire? No, that is for locusts. Aha, I know some Hamelinian Trickery. Okay, here’s what we’re going to do. I will play my flute,” luckily, he has brought his favorite instrument with him, “and when I play, the rats, mesmerized by the melody of mellow mice, as all rogue rodents, will follow me. And then you must, by applying the plaster, restore to a sound state the dam, anchoring the wall and undo the damage that has been done.⁶” And so, as the pied piper plays... ❧

⁴Ovid, XI, 630–632.

⁵Quran, 34:16.

⁶CIH, 541, 60–61.

Varaz picks up a flute and starts playing. And then he walks out the room. What should they do? Follow him? They look at each other.

—“Where did he go?”

But he quickly returns and sits down on the other cushion. Or was it the same? This is getting all very confusing. But also so exciting!

—“Oh, children, I don’t want to lure you away with my lurid play, for who ever pays the piper calls the tune.”

And then you wouldn’t hear the Princess exclaim.
~“There, a big stone, at that cave!” They land and just as they want to push the round stone aside. . . . A voice.
~“Finally! Where were you guys? This was supposed to be just for three days, like with that other fellow!” You won’t believe this, children. It’s the stone. It’s talking. 🗿

—“Stones don’t talk!”

—“Well, not here on earth they don’t. But remember, Shirowe, this one is from the moon.”

The Knight is equally surprised.

~“You can talk?”

~“And you’re deaf?” A little affronted, the Knight replies.

~“No!”

~“So, then step aside and let me do my job.” And before their surprised eyes, the talking stone starts rolling away from the opening of the cave. They can hear a lot of loud

~“YAWN,” he imitates some yawning, “YAWN!!”

~“What is that noise, Princess?” But before she can answer, some young men step outside the cave. The high priest is relieved.

~“Greetings, fine young men, the Moon goddess will be pleased to hear that you are alright.”

~“Go away, you heathen. Go tell your vile Emperor that we will never denounce our Lord IESOUS ΧRISTOS!”

~“He will be pleased to hear that.” The men look astonished at the Princess who said that.

~“I think you did not understand us. Let me introduce ourselves. I am Honi the Square-drawer and these are my companions.”

~“Greetings. How many of you are there?” They all start shouting.

~“Three?”

~“Five!”

~“No, seven!”

~“What, no, eight, counting the dog!”

~“What dog?” Children, the youngsters don’t seem to know either. I guess they are still groggy from their long sleep, so, only God knows best how many they were.⁷ The Knight now wants to know.

~“Honi, why are you called the square-drawer?” His companions start to chuckle.

~“I don’t know. It just a name.”

~“No, it’s not, Honi, don’t lie,” one of them replies, “it’s because you were going to ask God to make it rain and so you drew a square in the sand and stood inside it and then you brazenly told the Lord that you wouldn’t come out of it until He would send rains to fill the cisterns, trenches and reservoirs.⁸”

~“And did it work?” They all—except for Honi—burst out in laughter.

~“No, it was supposed to be a circle. Not a square, ha, ha! Honi, he’s such a square!” Honi just shrugs his shoulders while his three-to-eight companions are laughing. When their laughter dies out, Honi exclaims forcefully.

~“What matters is that we will only worship our Lord IESOUS ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ. The One and Only, you know.” The Moonstone answers him.

~“Right, I remember, that was the man I protected, for three days, in his grave,” and then adds, in a reproaching tone, “Not for two hundred plus years, like you lazy sleepers!”

~“Wait? What two hundred years? We just took a nap! To avoid the heat of the day. Look, the figs I just harvested are still juicy and full of sap. Here, have one.”

~“No, thank you. Figs always have this weird effect on me.”

⁷Quran, 18:22.

⁸Babylonian Talmud, 19a.

Meanwhile, one of the young men lets out a shout.

~“Oh, Honi, look, remember, that area over there where we planted vineyards? Now it produces olives. And that plot over there, we planted with olives but now it produces grain! The world has completely changed!”⁹”

~“Indeed. You went to sleep for fear of the Emperor’s persecution, but he changed his mind—well, they actually changed emperors—or something like that—I am no history buff. Anyway, now, you only need to fear God.”

~“Wow? Really?”

~“If you will go to the city, on each of its gates, you will find the sign of the cross thereupon.”¹⁰”

~“Blessed be our Lord!”

~“Amen!”

~“As they say, it’s all in a good night’s rest.”

~“So, no more persecutions?” The Princess looks a little crestfallen.

~“Well, as long as you are not going to dwell upon how many natures your Lord has.”

~“Nature?”

~“Or nurture. I am not sure. Princesses like to stay away from ontological debates.”

~“As do moonstones. And with this, I then will take my leave, seeing that my previous charge is now in good hands. To my next assignment! *Xaire* [Bye].” And as a rolling stone, he thunders through the valley, making fish and fowl alike jump aside. And rats too. Rats, what about those rats? 🐀

He returns to the other side. That is the Captain’s spot and he is saving the dam—it is not easy, but so far, she has been able to follow. From the looks of it, so does Āzar.

—“Yeah, Varaz, did the rats eat the dam?”

—“No, Āzar, luckily...”

HAmelinian Trickery did its job. The rats are lured by the piper, clothed in many colors, to their calvary.¹¹ And

⁹Jerusalem Talmud, 3.9.66d.

¹⁰Golden Legend, IV.

¹¹Rat Catcher’s House, Inscription.

while he leads them away, the workers quickly fix the dam. But some of the rats, they look back. The Captain can see their little brains twitch and writhe—imitating a high pitch voice of a rat—:

~“Should we obey the Queen’s orders, or get entranced by the enticing entertainment of the pied piper? What should we do?” The Captain remembers that rats are not particularly known for their loyalty. So, he keeps playing, leading them into the jungle. But remember those thorny bushes. Yeah, they already are growing there and so, not paying attention to the road, our poor Captain steps onto a thorn. Ow, ow, ow!

Varaz is jumping up and down on one leg. Oh, no, he is going to fall. On them!

THE Captain, he is falling—the girls let out a little shriek as he plunges in front of their cushion—into a deep pit! Wow. That’s a deep pit! He can barely see. There, on the rim of the pit, the eyes of hundred rats staring at him. Should he continue playing his flute? That would make them all jump into the pit as well, trapping them forever. Only, what about him? Well, he’ll figure that out later. But, look...

—“What, Varaz?”

Oh, right, Varaz is again on the other cushion.

THE Knight points down the valley. It’s the Moonstone. But the Moonstone is not moving?

~“What happened to him, you think, Princess?” They leave the three-to-eight sleepers, who are now grilling the high priest about his pagan beliefs, demanding that he denounces his false faith. As it so often happens, children, when the persecuted perseveres, a more severe persecutor he becomes. So, it might get ugly again.

~“Yeah, my Knight, let’s find out. These guys don’t need us anymore.” But then something happens...

As he walks quickly to the other side, his audience gasps. And for the next few passages, he is going to have to jump even more from one to the other. It’ll get everyone dizzy.

Just as the Captain wants to play his flute again, the eyes of the rats change from mystified to terrified. The hair on the back of their little necks is standing up! Something has scared them, and with a loud shriek, they disappear. Children, something really bad...—rats are not that easily rattled, you know—oh, dear? He turns... 🐭

—“What is it, Varaz?”

TO the grumbling Moonstone.

~“Esteemed Flint of the Night Goddess, what’s the matter?”

~“My luck! I got a hard tire!”

~“Is that not a good thing?”

~“Not if you’re a stone it is.”

~“Do you have a spare?”

~“My mistress could only spare me. But if I don’t... She is not going to spare me either.”

~“Perhaps you can fix it?”

~“Yes! That’s it! With some hail! That’ll soften it up,” he licks his finger and sticks it up in the wind—wait, that’s not possible, stones don’t have fingers—anyway, “according to the local forecast, the next hail is not before tomorrow evening though. *Āy wāy*.” The Knight wants to know how he can be sure of that, but the Princess interrupts him—see, children, the Knight sometimes lets himself being distracted with silly questions. In a story, not the how matters, but the what-is-next.

~“O Great Moonolith, is that then not good news?”

~“No! I am already late for my next assignment. And if... my Mistress will never forgive me if I don’t put this great evil to rest!”

~“Great evil?!”

~“And frightening!” What great and frightening evil is he talking about, children? 🐭

Varaz is now jumping from one cushion to another. It’s so funny, but also so confusing. Try to giggle and concentrate at the same time. Not easy!

—“What is it, Varaz?”

OH no. No, no, no. When the Captain turns around, he sees ...enormous... horrifying... gigantic ... horrendous ... gargantuan ... horrific... —just in time to reach the other cushion again—when the Moonstone exclaims ~“It’s the four lions of the Queen of Sheba! They are still on the loose. I have to prevent them from causing great evil in the Land of Frankincense and Spices. As my Mistress commanded me: roll from the Land of Israel to close off the mouth of the den.¹²” Lions on the loose! Children, perhaps we better close the doors before.... ❧

Wait, where is this now?

—“Varaz, who... what is... where...?”

He’s already back on that other cushion where the Captain was. Or was it the other way round?

—“Children, it’s a ...,” he whispers the next word, “...lion.”

And then lets out a loud roar which makes them all almost tumble from their cushions.

—“Oh no!”

With a loud bellow, the lion announces itself.
~“Welcome, fearless Seafarer—I don’t get those that often in these regions—welcome to my humble den. I am Daniel the Square Lion.” The Captain is trembling all over his body. He looks around, but there is no escape!
~“I... Are ... are you going to eat me?”
~“Eat you? No, no. I just had lunch. I am not hungry now,” the Captain lets out a sigh of relief, “but by sunset, well, then I normally get hungry.” Well, don’t we all know that saying

χwar χwāb ast

χwār χwāhast

...

sun’s sleepy

supper summons

right, children? ❧

He is very proud of this little verse he has composed. And even more of

¹²Midrash Tehillim.

what he did with it: gathering all his courage together, he had stepped up to his teacher, Nagisā, addressing her with another poem of his

*For fair poetess
while wit's low
words will flow
far from poem-less.*

And then he had offered her his dinner verse for her to use in her songs at the banquet. Perhaps it had been a little presumptuous of him, but she had nonetheless been pleased with it. And—the best part—had kissed him on the cheek. There was though a moral to the story: you can never please two masters. For apparently, master Pahrbad didn't take his flirty lines too kindly! But not the situation to be rectified today.

—“Oh, no, Varaz. The Lion is going to eat him!”

Wait. Which cushion did he just sit on?

THE Princess exclaims

~“Moonstone, perhaps we can be of help. We have a flying carpet.”

~“I doubt it can carry me.”

~“Oh, no, it can carry the weight of a thousand men.”

~“While a grave matter, it is not a matter of gravity.”

~“Huh?”

~“See, lunar and terrestrial magic, it just clashes. That's why my Mistress has taken refuge in the sky.” Before the Knight can raise his objection, the Princess quickly proposes.

~“But we can guard the den for you. Until hail has hailed. . . , has healed your heel, has . . . ,” I think, children, the Princess's magic is getting muddled by the Moonstone's proximity, so she quickly shakes it off, “Moonstone, with our flying carpet, we will get there in no time and make sure no lion escapes!”

~“But these lions, they are ferocious felines.”

~“Don't worry, Lunar Lithic, we have had our run-ins with lions and stuff before. We'll handle it, won't we, Knight?” The Knight though is not all too convinced. They never faced a lion before. But then, is a lion not just a dragon without wings?

~“Yes, we will, Son of the Sun.”

~“Of the Moon!”

~“But didn’t the high priest say before that the Moon is the Sun’s consort and ...” The Princess quickly drags him on the carpet before he starts getting some solar magic on his head.

~“See you soon, Moonstone! *Paddrod* [bye]!” But what the Princess and her Knight do not know... 🐾

—“What, Varaz?”

Just in time for the cushion jump.

IS that the lion has an objection.

~“Seafarer, I cannot eat you. . .”

~“You can’t?” But the little hope the Captain has, it’s quickly dashed to pieces.

~“...with that thorn in your foot. I don’t want it to get stuck between my teeth. Come, let me help you. Agony only tenses the muscles and hardens the fibers. And I like my supper tender.” The Captain looks up. As if help might come from that direction? But who would even know he was here. . .!? Luckily, the sun is still wide awake, so not yet supper time. The lion takes the plant of his foot, pricked with a thorn, and then puts thereto his diligent cure.¹³ Wooh, that’s a relief. So, to kill the time—rather than himself—the Captain asks

~“Daniel, you said you’re a square lion? What does that mean?”

~“You must surely have heard of the four arch-lions of the Queen of Sheba. Each sitting perched in the corner of her chamber. Ready to do her bidding. But then that wicked king Darius. . .”

~“Of the Medes?”

~“Or the Persians or the Parthians—who knows?—they all look the same to me. Anyway, he knocks down our Mistress and takes her magical ruby,” the lion shakes his manes—but just the strong gush of wind alone blows him down, in front of the lion.¹⁴ The Captain quickly gets back on his feet, “And

¹³Golden Legend, V.

¹⁴Al-Isti’ab, 2.684.

now my Mistress has fled and the Land of Frankincense and Spices is going to be ruled by those Persians—or Medes or Parthians, what do I know! All the good things that are going to happen! Awful, just awful! Not at all what our Mistress wanted. She had a much bleaker future in mind for the Land of Frankincense and Spices. So, in her magnificent malevolence, she had an ingenious plan.”

~“What?”

~“To imbue the walls of her palace with the Sap of Prescience, so that, when the time of wanton wrongdoing was nigh, the wall would write words of forewarning.”

MENE: numbered are the days that it rains

MENE: numbered are the days of your reign

TEKEL: weighed on the scales you were found wanting

UPHARSIN: your kingdom will fall

*to the Medes and the Persians.*¹⁵

~“And did it work?”

~“Uhm,” Daniel the Lion looks a little dejected, “no, not really. She just had gone out shopping, so, she didn’t see it on time. But, luckily, she also had a plan B!”

~“You mean, like a back-up plan?”

~“Well, it was more like a leap-forward plan. See, at the last lingering of her wicked witchcraft, the four of us, her arch-lions, from the four corners of the room, we all leapt forward simultaneously, to the center of the square, with such a force, that four became one. Square thus collapsing into the single singularity of yours truly.” He makes a little bow. Which again almost knocks the Captain down just from the movement of the air. And the lion’s breath doesn’t help either. Pfheew! I think he had some rats for desert. 🐭

He pretends to look out the window.

—“But is that the sun settling to set down? Yep, I think I saw a yawn. You know what that means, children?”

¹⁵Daniel, VI, 26–28.

—“Oh, no, Varaz, supper time.”

One more jump across the other cushion.

THE Knight thinks so too.

~“Princess, as the Moon’s spouse is hinting by winking at the horizon with its hues of red and purple,” she looks at him puzzled—what is he babbling about, “sunset, my dear, I was describing the sunset! Never mind! What I’m saying is that I am famished. Can we not stop? Look down there. Some fields of that famous food of the Jews: manna! I heard it’s very yummy.” The Princess is a bit hungry too. And manna, perhaps not as good as the *shiftenag* [marzipan] of the Queen of Sweetness, but it’s rumored to taste like truffles, and the juice is a remedy for evil eye.¹⁶ You can always use some extra antidote, the Princess thinks, so, she wouldn’t mind trying some. And perhaps a roasted quail to go with it? ❧

Now he is making himself getting hungry, but his story is not finished yet.

—“But...but..., Varaz, if they don’t come in time, the lion is going to eat the Captain.”

HUNGER is a powerful motivator... And so, while the Knight’s stomach is grumbling..., and the Princess now craves some *shiftenag*..., and the Square Lion licks his lips..., and the Captain says his last prayers... ❧

Before the children had entered, he had tied the two cushions together with a rope, running along the column to his left. And so, while saying that last bit, he moves his cushion in small jumps to the right. Like intended—and practiced several times—a malfunctioning prop, not something you want—go ask that poor acrobat of the other day—the other cushion, being tethered to his, is now pulled at the same time to the middle. And when the two cushions touch, he jumps up.

BUT Justice is a stronger compulsor. And from the sky, on their magic carpet, the Princess and the Knight swoop in, and save the Captain from the maw of the Square Lion. ❧

—“Yay!”

¹⁶Mishkat al-Masabih, 4569.

But, children, that is not the end of their encounter with the lion.¹⁷ For the Square Lion jumps out of the pit, in pursuit of the magic carpet. But he is not fast enough. No way! However, evil can be resourceful, especially leonine one. And so, he pulls the *panjshagrān* and shoots five lion teeth towards the carpet. And with their corrosive saliva, the teeth sap the magical strength of the carpet. It slows down. And worse, it starts swerving downwards. A little more, and Daniel might be able to jump on it! They need a plan! ~“Look, the sea. And there is my ship. I’ll jump in the water. With less weight, the carpet will not fly too low.” ~“Yes, we will lure the lion away. And the Moon and the Sun and all the stars in between willing, we will stay afloat and the lion will not catch us.” A good plan! And so—he pushes the second cushion behind him—while the Captain quickly swims to his boat, the Knight stirs on the carpet. ~“Fly, carpet, fly!” But those teeth can bite, and the carpet is huffing and puffing and . . . I think it’s falling asleep. But even magical fairies cannot fly while they’re asleep, let alone silken carpets with their fine embroideries. Will this then be the end of our intrepid duo, children? 🐾

Wait, where did that other cushion go? There is a pause and they all look at each other.

—“What is happening, Varaz.”

Well, as the bard sings
To find the direction home
To complete the fate unknown
*You have to be like a rolling stone.*¹⁸

And so, it took a little time for the Moonstone to come thundering down the valley. But there he is!

~“Look, my Princess, the Stone has returned. We have to lead the lion right to it!”

~“Yes, let the circular squash the square!”

¹⁷Al-Isti’ab, 2.684.

¹⁸Bob Dylan (paraphrased).

~“Huh?”

~“Oh, that’s just a saying.” And so, as the lion, unaware of his stony fate, collides head on with the stone, a great explosion ensues. For you cannot square a circle, it is just impossible and impossible things tend to explode. And the shock waves, it lifts the carpet hundred of miles in one direction. And the Captain’s ship hundred in the other. And so, untangled once more, so that, as ordained to be obligato by the Oracle of the Orb that their stories shall segue sagaciously yet separately, serendipitously yet sequentially. . . 🐾

Pretending to be suddenly startled by something—although it was more because he was running out of s-words, ha, ha.

—“Oh, children, what is that?”

He points to the wall behind them.

—“What is it, Varaz?”

—“That writing on the wall. Can you read it?” What writing? Now, that she finally figured out the whole story—and it had been a good one—, something else to confuse them?

—“I don’t see anything.”

—“There is no writing on the wall, dumbo.”

—“So, the polite request for the royal company to proceed to the dining room, I am just making that up? Have you forgotten, Shirowe, that it is written in stone that

χwar χwāb ast

χwār χwāhast

I, for one, am not going ignore such an important divination for the welfare of my stomach, ha, ha.”

—“Pff! You’re making it all up, Varaz. Like that thing, a *panjshagrān*, what is that supposed to be? I thought there were only four lions [shagr] not five [panj].” Time for the *Bāmbishn* to come to his rescue.

—“The *panjagān*, a ballista capable of firing five arrows at once, used successfully in the conquest of Yemen, the Land of Frankincense and Spices.” Why is Abrangih nodding? She knew that? So, she quickly follows her out to the dining hall, to inquire about it.

—“Your Majesty, I apologize for tweaking once in a while the truth.”

—“A bard’s prerogative. As probably also surmised, in the kingly lists,

there is no Darius the Mede, and certainly not the father of Kurosh [Cyrus] of house Haḫāmanesh [Achaemenids]. Whence a rabbinical interpolation the purpose of which is not entirely clear.”

—“I wondered about that too, Your Majesty.” As she is almost out of the door, she turns around.

—“The impossibility of squaring the circle, is your postulate based on the transcendence of the ratio of circumference over radius? A property probably very hard to establish nonetheless.” That’s a whole bunch of words he has no clue what they mean.

—“Uhm no, Your Majesty, I don’t know what you mean. I just thought it sounded funny.” Does that mean that the *Bāmbishn* has actually tried to square a circle, whatever that means?